Bridge Bidding Guide: Combined Handouts

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Contents

1 Preface: The Objectives of Bidding **3**

2 Evaluating Hand Strength **3**

3 Opening Bids and Responding at the 1-Level **3**

4 Responding to 1 Major **3**
4.1 Hand Strength Zones . . . 3
4.2 Responding with a Fit . . . 4
4.3 Responding without a Fit ($\leq$ 2 Support) . . . 4
4.4 Summary Table (System: 2/1 GF) . . . 4

5 Opener's Rebids: Describing the Hand **5**
5.1 Summary: Opening Bids (12–21 HCP) . . . 5
5.2 Responder's Initial Actions (After a Minor Opening) . . . 5
5.3 Detailed Opener's Rebid Actions . . . 5
5.3.1 Minimum Range (12–15 HCP) . . . 5
5.3.2 Medium Range (16–18 HCP) . . . 5
5.3.3 Maximum Range (19–21 HCP) . . . 6

6 System after 1NT **6**
6.1 Stayman Convention (2♣) . . . 6
6.1.1 Opener's Initial Responses . . . 6
6.1.2 Responder's Rebids after 2♢ (No Major) . . . 6
6.1.3 Responder's Rebids after 2♡/2♠ (Fit Found) . . . 6
6.1.4 Special Case: Garbage Stayman . . . 6
6.2 Jacoby Transfers (2♢ / 2♡) . . . 7
6.3 Texas Transfers (4♢ / 4♡) . . . 7
6.4 6-4 Majors . . . 7
6.5 Summary of Combined 1NT Sequences . . . 7

7 Competitive Bidding: Overcalls and Takeout Doubles **7**
7.1 Suit Overcalls (Direct Position) . . . 7
7.2 Advancing to Suit Overcalls (NFC System) . . . 7
7.3 NT Overcalls . . . 8
7.4 Takeout Doubles (X) . . . 8
7.5 Advancing to the Takeout Double . . . 8
7.6 Powerhouse Hands (17+ HCP) . . . 8
7.7 Action when RHO Intervenes . . . 8

8 Slam Bidding: RKCB **9**

9 Responses after Interference **9**
9.1 Core Philosophy . . . 9
9.2 Responses after 1-Level Overcalls . . . 9
9.2.1 Showing Support . . . 9
9.2.2 No Support: Strong Free Bid System . . . 9
9.2.3 Negative Doubles (×) . . . 9
9.3 Bidding after Takeout Double (X) . . . 10
9.3.1 After 1-Level Minor Opening + (X) . . . 10
9.3.2 After 1-Level Major Opening + (X) . . . 10
9.4 After Fourth Place Double . . . 10

1. Preface: The Objectives of Bidding

The primary objective of bidding is to find the most suitable contract. This process consists of two fundamental goals:

1. **Finding a Fit:** Discovering a trump fit (typically 8+ combined cards in a suit).
2. **Evaluating Game Potential:** Determining whether the partnership has sufficient combined strength to reach game.

As a general rule, a combined total of **25 High Card Points (HCP)** is considered the **Game Line**. When bidding towards game, partnerships follow a strict order of priority:

- **First Priority (Major Suits):** 4♡ or 4♠ (requires only 10 tricks and scores favorably with an 8+ card fit).
- **Second Priority (No-Trump):** 3NT (requires 9 tricks and serves as the primary game target without an 8-card major fit).
- **Last Resort (Minor Suits):** 5♣ or 5♢ (requires 11 tricks, making it significantly harder to make).

2. Evaluating Hand Strength

Bidding is a communication where you and your partner describe each other's hands to find a fit and determine how high to play.

- **HCP Scale:** Ace = 4, King = 3, Queen = 2, Jack = 1.
- **Limited Bids:** Bids that define a narrow point range (e.g., 1NT opening = 15–17 HCP). These allow partner to "do the math" to decide to Pass, Invite, or Bid Game.
- **Unlimited Bids:** Bids with no defined upper limit (e.g., a new suit at the 1-level). These are **Forcing**—partner must bid again.

3. Opening Bids and Responding at the 1-Level

The **Opener** holds **12+ HCP**. Majors (♡/♠) take priority over Minors (♣/♢).

- **1♡ or 1♠:** Promises 12–21 HCP and a 5+ card suit.
- **1♣ or 1♢:** Promises 12–21 HCP and a 3+ card suit.
- **1NT:** 15–17 HCP, balanced hand, no voids or singletons.

Responding: If partner opens and you have **6+ HCP**, you must respond.

- **One Over One:** Bidding a new suit at the 1-level. Shows 6+ HCP and 4+ cards. **Unlimited and Forcing**.
- **Two Over One (2/1):** Bidding a new suit at the 2-level (e.g., 1♠–2♣). Shows 13+ HCP. **Game Forcing (GF)**.
- **Support:** If you have a fit (8+ cards combined), raise partner's suit immediately.

4. Responding to 1 Major

1M Opening: 12–21 HCP, 5+ cards. Finding a Major fit (8+ cards combined) is our first priority. Suit ranking: ♠ > ♡ > ♢ > ♣.

4.1 Hand Strength Zones

Before bidding, categorize your hand into one of three zones based on High Card Points (HCP). Identifying your zone allows partner to "do the math" and decide whether to stop, invite, or bid Game.

Category	Opener	Responder
MIN (Minimum)	12–15 HCP	6–10 HCP
MED (Medium)	15–18 HCP	10–12 HCP
MAX (Maximum)	18+ HCP	13+ HCP (GF)

4.2 Responding with a Fit

With Exactly 3-Card Support

- **2M (Simple Raise):** 6–9 HCP.
- **1NT → 3M (Limit Raise):** 10–12 HCP. (The "Two-Step" approach)

Opener's action after a simple raise (1M–2M):

- **MIN:** Pass.
- **MED:** 3M (Invitation).
- **MAX:** 4M (Accept Invitation).

With 4+ Card Support (Conventional)

- **Bergen Raises:** Used after a 1M opening with **exactly 4-card support**:
  - **3♣* (Constructive):** 7–9 HCP (MIN-MED).
  - **3♢* (Limit Raise):** 10–12 HCP (MED).
  - **3M (Preemptive, Weak):** 3–6 HCP (MIN).

  With 9 trumps, the "Law of Total Tricks" says we are safe at the 3-level even with few points.
- **Jacoby 2NT (GF):** 13+ HCP (MAX) and 4+ card support. Response: 1M–2NT*. This bid is Game Forcing—we cannot stop until Game is reached. Opener's rebids:
  - New suit at 3-level: Shows a **Singleton or Void**.
  - 4M: Minimum hand (12–14), no shortness.
  - 3NT: Medium hand (15–17), no shortness.
- **Splinters (4X):** 12–15 HCP, 4+ support, and a **singleton/void** in the bid suit (e.g., 4♣ / 4♢).
- **Mini-Splinter (3♠ after 1♡):** 9–11 HCP, 4+ support, and shortness somewhere. Opener can bid 3NT to ask where the shortness is.

4.3 Responding without a Fit ($\leq$ 2 Support)

- **1NT (Semi-Forcing):** 5–12 HCP. The "Dustbin" bid to keep the auction alive. Opener can **Pass** with a flat MIN hand (5-3-3-2 and 12–14 HCP). If Opener has 15+ HCP or an unbalanced hand, they **must** rebid. It keeps us in a safe 1NT contract when Game isn't possible and the Major isn't fitting.
- **New Suit at 2-level:** 13+ HCP. Sets a **Game Force**.

4.4 Summary Table (System: 2/1 GF)

Golden Rule: If you have a fit and 25+ total HCP, you **must** reach Game!

Strength	Support	Your Bid
0–6 HCP	4+ cards	**3M** (Preemptive)
6–9 HCP	3 cards	**2M** (Simple)
7–9 HCP	4+ cards	**3♣*** (Bergen)
10–12 HCP	3 cards	**1NT** → **3M** (Limit)
10–12 HCP	4+ cards	**3♢*** (Bergen)
12–15 HCP	4+ cards	**4X** (Splinter)
13+ HCP	4+ cards	**2NT** (Jacoby GF)
13+ HCP	≤ 3 cards	**2-over-1** (GF)

5. Opener's Rebids: Describing the Hand

5.1 Summary: Opening Bids (12–21 HCP)

- **1NT:** 15–17 HCP, Balanced.
- **1♡/ 1♠:** 12–21 HCP, 5+ cards.
- **1♣/ 1♢:** 12–21 HCP, 3+ cards.

5.2 Responder's Initial Actions (After a Minor Opening)

Bid	Strength	Requirement/Meaning
1-over-1	6+ HCP	4+ cards, Forcing 1 Round (F1). Major first.
1NT	6–10 HCP	Balanced, denies 4-card Major (if over 1m).
2NT	11–12 HCP	Balanced, Invitational (to 1m opening).
2/1 GF	13+ HCP	Game Forcing (after 1M or 1♢ opening).

5.3 Detailed Opener's Rebid Actions

After Responder's 1-level suit response, Opener must define their hand within one of three ranges:

5.3.1 Minimum Range (12–15 HCP)

- **Re-bid 1NT:** 12–14 HCP, Balanced (denies 4-card support or second suit).
- **Simple Raise (2-level):** 12–15 HCP, 4-card support for partner's Major.
- **Repeat Own Suit (2-level):** 12–15 HCP, 6+ cards in opening suit (non-forcing).
- **New Suit (1-level):** 12–18 HCP, 4+ cards. (e.g., 1♣ - 1♢ - 1♡).
- **New Suit (2-level):** 12–15 HCP, 5-4 distribution, second suit is lower-ranking (non-reverse).

5.3.2 Medium Range (16–18 HCP)

- **Jump Raise (3-level):** 16–18 HCP, 4-card support. Invitational.
- **Jump Repeat (3-level):** 16–18 HCP, Very strong 6+ card suit. Invitational.
- **Jump Re-bid 2NT:** 18–19 HCP, Balanced hand. Invitational to 3NT.
- **Reverse Bid:** 17+ HCP, Unbalanced hand, second suit is higher-ranking.

5.3.3 Maximum Range (19–21 HCP)

- **Reverse bid, Re-bid 2NT:** Same as Medium Range.
- **Jump Shift:** 19+ HCP. Bidding a **new** suit at one level higher than necessary. **Game Forcing**.

6. System after 1NT

1NT opening shows a balanced hand with **15–17 HCP**. This is a **Limited Bid**. After a 1NT opening, use specialized tools to find a 4-4 or 5-3 Major fit.

6.1 Stayman Convention (2♣)

Used when Responder has **8+ HCP** and at least one **exact 4-card** Major.

6.1.1 Opener's Initial Responses

- **2♢:** No 4-card Major.
- **2♡:** At least 4 Hearts. (May also have 4 Spades).
- **2♠:** At least 4 Spades. (Denies 4 Hearts).

6.1.2 Responder's Rebids after 2♢ (No Major)

If Opener denies a Major, Responder must decide the final contract:

- **2NT: Invitational** (8–9 HCP). Asks Opener to bid 3NT with a maximum (17) or Pass with a minimum (15).
- **3NT: To Play** (10–15 HCP). Responder has enough for game but no 5-card Major to explore further.
- **2♡/2♠: Invitational** (8–9 HCP). Showing 5-4 Major distribution (5 cards in the bid suit) and invitational strength.
- **Smolen (3♡/3♠): Game Forcing** (10+ HCP). Showing a 5-4 Major distribution (Jump in the 4-card suit to show 5 cards in **the other**).

6.1.3 Responder's Rebids after 2♡/2♠ (Fit Found)

If a fit is found, Responder clarifies the strength:

- **Raise to 3-level: Invitational** (8–9 HCP). E.g., 1NT – 2♣; 2♡ – 3♡. Opener passes with minimum, bids 4 with maximum.
- **Raise to 4-level: To Play** (10+ HCP). Sets the final contract in the fit Major.
- **3NT: Choice of Games**. Usually shows 4 cards in the *other* Major (if Opener bid 2♡, Responder has 4 Spades). Opener can pass 3NT or correct to 4 of the other Major with a 4-4 fit.

6.1.4 Special Case: Garbage Stayman

With a weak hand (0–7 HCP) and short ♣ (singleton/void) but length in the other three suits (e.g., 4-4-4-1, 5-4-4-0), Responder can bid 2♣, and pass after any rebids by opener.

6.2 Jacoby Transfers (2♢ / 2♡)

Used to show a 5+ card Major. 2♢ → 2♡; 2♡ → 2♠. After Opener completes the transfer:

- **Pass:** Weak (0–7 HCP).
- **2NT:** Invitational (8–9 HCP) with exactly 5 cards.
- **3NT:** Game values (10–15 HCP) with exactly 5 cards. Opener picks between 3NT and 4 of the Major.
- **New Minor:** Game Forcing (10+ HCP) showing a second suit.
- **3♡/3♠ (Original suit):** Invitational (8–9 HCP) with 6+ cards.
- **4♡/4♠ (Original suit):** 6+ card major with game interest.
- **2♠ after 2♢→2♡ transfer:** 5-5 Majors with invitational value.
- **3♡ after 2♡→2♠ transfer:** 5-5 Majors with game forcing value.

6.3 Texas Transfers (4♢ / 4♡)

A hand with **6+ card Majors** and Game values. 4♢→ 4♡; 4♡→ 4♠. Directly places the contract while keeping the strong hand hidden. After Opener completes the transfer:

- **Pass:** Game Value only, no slam interest.
- **4NT:** Invitational (8–9 HCP) with exactly 5 cards.

Note: the May 14 source annotates the Pass line "(0–7 HCP)"; that annotation is omitted here because it conflicts with the game-values requirement for a Texas Transfer stated just above — please confirm if you want it restored.

6.4 6-4 Majors

We may still use Texas transfer when we have 6-4 in Majors and hear a 2♢ response after Stayman. If we hear a 2♡ or 2♠ response, then we immediately know we have a fit in some major.

6.5 Summary of Combined 1NT Sequences

Sequence	Responder's Strength	Meaning	Next Goal
1NT – 2♣; 2♢ – 2NT	8–9 HCP	Invitational	3NT or Pass
1NT – 2♣; 2♢ – 3♠	10+ HCP	5♡ and 4♠, game value+	3NT or 4♡
1NT – 2♣; 2♡ – 3NT	10+ HCP	no 4♡, usually 4♠, game value+	3NT or 4♠
1NT – 2♢; 2♡ – 2NT	8–9 HCP	5♡, Invite	3♡ or 3NT or 4♡
1NT – 2♡; 2♠ – 3♠	8–9 HCP	6+♠, Invite	3♠ or 4♠
1NT – 4♢; 4♡	10+ HCP	Texas Transfer	To Play

7. Competitive Bidding: Overcalls and Takeout Doubles

7.1 Suit Overcalls (Direct Position)

- **1-Level Overcall:** 8–16 HCP with a 5+ card suit. Priority is placed on **lead-directing quality** rather than raw HCP.
- **2-Level Overcall:** 11–16 HCP with a very solid 5+ or 6-card suit. Requires discipline and safety considerations due to the risk of being doubled.

7.2 Advancing to Suit Overcalls (NFC System)

NFC: Non-Forcing Constructive. All responses except the Cue-bid are non-forcing.

Bid	Strength	Meaning / Requirements
Simple New Suit	10–13 HCP	Natural, 5+ (usually 6+) card suit; **Non-Forcing**.
Simple Raise	6–10 pts	3+ card support for partner's suit.
Cue-bid (Direct)	10+ Good HCP	**The only forcing move**. Shows 3+ support (or 14+ HCP without).
Jump in New Suit	13–15 pts	Natural, 6+ card suit; Invitational.
Jump Cue-bid	10+ Adj. pts	4+ card support; Invitational.
Double Jump Cue	Game Force	Splinter: 4+ support, shortness in bid suit.
1NT Response	9–12 HCP	Balanced, stopper in opponent's suit; denies 3-card Major fit.
Jump 2NT	13–15 HCP	Balanced, strong stoppers; invites 3NT.

7.3 NT Overcalls

- **Direct 1NT Overcall:** 15–18 HCP, balanced hand with a stopper in the opponent's suit. Systems (Stayman/Transfers) are usually ON.
- **Balancing 1NT Overcall:** 11–14 HCP, balanced hand.
- **Responses Over 2-Level Overcall:** 2NT shows a good 9 to weak 12 HCP with a stopper.

7.4 Takeout Doubles (X)

Standard Criteria for Takeout:

- **Strength:** 12+ HCP (Opening values).
- **Shortness:** Usually 0–2 cards in the opponent's opened suit.
- **Support:** 3+ cards in all unbid suits (ideally 4 cards in unbid Majors).

7.5 Advancing to the Takeout Double

You MUST bid if RHO passes, even with 0 HCP.

Advancer HCP	Action	Meaning
0 – 8 HCP	Simple Suit Bid	Cheapest level; Forced response (promises 4 cards).
9 – 11 HCP	Jump in Suit	Invitational to game; Non-forcing.
12+ HCP	Game or Cue-bid	Game bidding directly or forcing cue-bid to ask for info.
6 – 9 HCP	1NT	Balanced, stopper in opponent's suit.
10 – 12 HCP	2NT	Balanced, stopper, Invitational to 3NT.
13+ HCP	3NT	Balanced, stopper, to play.

7.6 Powerhouse Hands (17+ HCP)

For hands too strong for a direct overcall, Double first then clarify on the next round.

- **Double then Bid New Suit:** 17+ HCP with a strong 5+ card suit.
- **Double then Bid NT:** 19–21 HCP, balanced with a stopper.
- **Double then Raise Partner:** 16–18 HCP with 4+ card support for partner.

7.7 Action when RHO Intervenes

If the opponent between you and partner bids, you are no longer forced to bid:

- **Pass:** 0–5 HCP.
- **1-level New Suit:** Promises 6+ HCP.
- **Responsive Double:** Shows strength but no clear fit; asks partner to show a 4-card suit.

8. Slam Bidding: RKCB

RKCB (4NT): Asking for 5 Key Cards (4 Aces + Trump King).

- 5♣: 1 or 4 key cards.
- 5♢: 0 or 3 key cards.
- 5♡: 2 or 5 key cards (No Trump Queen).
- 5♠: 2 or 5 key cards (With Trump Queen).

The other competitive items from that April 9 section (overcall ranges, takeout double, 1NT overcall) are covered in full in Section 6 above and are not repeated here.

9. Responses after Interference

9.1 Core Philosophy

- **Uncontested Auctions (Maintenance):** In standard auctions, the responder is responsible for "keeping the auction alive," often using forcing bids with minimum values.
- **Contested Auctions (Construction):** After an opponent overcalls, the opener is guaranteed another chance to bid. Since maintenance pressure is removed, responder does not need to bid with weak hands.

9.2 Responses after 1-Level Overcalls

9.2.1 Showing Support

- **Simple Raise (e.g., 2♠):** 7–9 points and specific 3/4 card support requirements.
- **Jump Raise (e.g., 3♠):** Preemptive (weak), 4+ support.
- **Jump to Game (e.g., 4♠):** Preemptive, usually 4+ or 5+ support, sign-off.
- **Cuebid:** Strong! 10+ points with nice 3+ support. *Note: If partner opens a minor, you need a good 4+ cards for a nice fit.*

9.2.2 No Support: Strong Free Bid System

We use a strong free bid system: directly bidding a suit is strong, while bidding after a double is weak.

- **1-Level New Suit:** 8+ HCP, 4+ cards (or 5+ if opponent bid 1♡ and you bid ♠), one-round forcing.
- **2-Level New Suit:** 10+ HCP, 5+ cards, one-round forcing.
- **Jump Shift in New Suit:** Weak.
- **Jump Raise of Opener's Suit:** Preemptive.
- **Double first, then bid a new suit:** 6–10 points, 5+ suit, **Not Forcing**.

9.2.3 Negative Doubles (×)

Almost all negative doubles deny support for partner's suit. It contains many cases. The responder can respond as if the partner has 8+ HCP and 4 card in the unbid major.

- **Core Case:** Shows **exactly 4 cards** in the unbid Major with any 6+ point. *(A direct response promises 5+ cards).*
- **One suit to bid without enough strength:** Ready to rebid a suit. (If the suit is a minor, you might be prepared to show the suit in 3-level.)
- **Unbid Major Suit/Unbid 2 suits:** Ready for a pass/invitation/game bid according to the strength.

- **Weak Two-Suiters:** Ready to pass after any response.
- **Balanced Invitations:** Could be handling 2NT strength without stoppers or powerhouse with a stopper. Ready for a cuebid afterwards.
- **GF Support + Major:** Although we may have support in minor, we still want to try to find a major fit. Ready to bid a game or seek slam.

9.3 Bidding after Takeout Double (X)

9.3.1 After 1-Level Minor Opening + (X)

- **1-level New Suit:** 6+ HCP, Forcing for one round (F1).
- **Jump Shift:** Weak.
- **1NT:** 8–11 HCP, balanced, no 5+ card fit for opener.
- **Jump 2NT:** Limit Raise (11+ total points) with 5+ card support.
- **Redouble (XX):** 11+ HCP, usually balanced. Denies immediate fit; prepares to **penalize** opponents.

9.3.2 After 1-Level Major Opening + (X)

Semi-forcing 1NT and Bergen Raises are off since maintenance is unnecessary.

- **1-level New Suit:** 6+ HCP, Forcing for one round (F1).
- **Jump Shift:** Weak.
- **1NT (Good Raise):** 9–11 pts with 3-card support, or 7–10 pts with 4-card support. *(Simple 2-level raises become weaker: 5–8 pts).*
- **Jump 2NT:** Limit Raise or better (11+ total points) with 4+ card support.
- **Redouble (XX):** 11+ HCP balanced, denies support, searches for NT and penalty.

9.4 After Fourth Place Double

Support (Re)Double:

- Confirms an **exact 3-card support** in Responder's suit.
- Helps identify the optimal 5-3 or 4-4 fit early in contested auctions.
- Has **first priority**; other bids deny 3-card support.